SAMPLE

The eBook Business

Write, Package, and Sell Books in the Digital Marketplace

Aiman Sterling

Free sample: Introduction & Chapter 1
putrabooks.github.io

Introduction

You know things other people want to learn. Maybe you've spent years in a profession, mastered a hobby, solved a problem others struggle with, or accumulated knowledge that could help someone. That knowledge can become an eBook -- and that eBook can become income.

But writing the book is only half the battle. The other half -- the half most people never figure out -- is the business of eBooks: packaging, pricing, publishing, and selling.

This book covers both halves, with a focus on the second. Because the world is full of well-written eBooks that never sold a single copy, and full of mediocre eBooks that sell thousands. The difference isn't the writing. It's the business.

You're someone who has knowledge to share and wants to sell it as an eBook:

- A professional with expertise in your field.

- A hobbyist who's mastered a skill others want to learn.

- Someone who's solved a problem and wants to share the solution.

- A writer who wants to self-publish and sell directly to readers.

- Anyone who has valuable knowledge and wants to turn it into a digital product.

You don't need to be a professional writer. You need to be knowledgeable about your topic and willing to learn the publishing business.

This book takes you from idea to published eBook:

- Choosing a topic that has market demand.

- Validating the topic before you write (so you don't waste months on a book no one wants).

- Structuring and writing a non-fiction eBook.

- Editing and proofreading your work.

- Designing a cover that sells (or getting one designed affordably).

- Formatting for multiple platforms.

- Writing book descriptions that convert browsers into buyers.

- Pricing your eBook strategically.

- Choosing publishing platforms (Amazon KDP, Apple Books, Google Play, Gumroad, and others).

- Setting up publishing accounts.

- Publishing and launching your eBook.

- Marketing without a budget.

- Understanding royalties and getting paid.

The goal: publish one eBook on one platform.

This is not a book about writing craft. It won't teach you how to write beautiful prose or compelling narratives. It assumes you can write clearly and communicate your knowledge. The focus is on the publishing and selling system -- the business of eBooks.

This is also not a book about fiction publishing. While many of the principles overlap, the eBook business for fiction has different dynamics (series strategy, genre conventions, reader expectations). This book focuses on non-fiction -- knowledge-based eBooks that solve problems or teach skills.

Book 3 covers creating digital products in general (templates, guides, courses, etc.). Book 4 covers the mechanics of a single transaction. This book goes deep on eBooks specifically -- the full publishing pipeline from topic selection to platform launch. If you know you want to write and sell an eBook, this is your book.

Here's the core mindset shift: an eBook is not just a book. It's a product. And like any product, its success depends on:

- **Market demand:** Does someone want this?

- **Packaging:** Does the cover, title, and description make people want it?

- **Pricing:** Is it priced to sell?

- **Distribution:** Can people find and buy it?

- **Marketing:** Do people know it exists?

Writers who focus only on the writing fail at the other four. This book makes sure you don't.

- Knowledge or expertise in a topic.

- The ability to write clearly (not beautifully -- clearly).

- A computer and internet connection.

- Time to write and prepare the eBook (2-8 weeks depending on length).

- A small budget for a cover design (or design skills).

- The willingness to learn the publishing business.

If you have those, you can publish and sell an eBook. Let's begin.

What the eBook Business Actually Is

Chapter 1: What the eBook Business Actually Is

The eBook business is the business of creating, publishing, and selling digital books. It's a subset of the broader digital products world -- but with its own platforms, conventions, and economics. Before diving into the process, let's understand what this business actually looks like.

An eBook is a digital book -- a book in electronic format that can be read on a device (eReader, phone, tablet, computer). The eBook business is selling these digital books to readers through online platforms.

The core exchange: you package knowledge into a structured digital book. A reader pays for it. They receive a file they can read on their device. You receive a royalty from the sale.

In traditional publishing, a publisher buys the rights to your book, handles editing, design, distribution, and marketing, and pays you a royalty (typically 8-15% of the retail price). You give up control and most of the revenue.

In self-publishing, you keep all rights, handle everything yourself (or hire freelancers for specific tasks), and earn much higher royalties (35-70% of the retail price on most platforms). You keep control and most of the revenue -- but you also take on all the work and risk.

This book is about self-publishing. It's the path that gives you the most control, the highest royalties, and the fastest time to market.

eBooks are sold through platforms -- online marketplaces that host your book, process sales, and deliver the file to buyers. The major platforms include:

Note: Platform names, features, royalty structures, and market share change over time. Research current details before committing.

- **Amazon KDP (Kindle Direct Publishing):** The largest eBook marketplace. Reaches the most readers. Offers 35-70% royalties depending on pricing.

- **Apple Books:** Apple's eBook store. Strong in certain markets and genres.

- **Google Play Books:** Google's eBook platform. Reaches Android users globally.

- **Kobo:** Popular in certain countries (Canada, Europe). Has its own eReader devices.

- **Gumroad:** A direct-selling platform that lets you sell eBooks directly to your audience. You set the price and keep a larger share.

- **Other platforms:** Barnes & Noble Press, Smashwords (now Draft2Digital), and others.

You don't need to be on all platforms. For your first eBook, start with one -- most likely Amazon KDP because it has the largest audience -- and expand later.

Author -> Platform -> Reader

You upload your eBook to a platform. The platform lists it in their store. A reader finds it, buys it, and the platform delivers the file. The platform takes a percentage (their fee) and pays you the rest (your royalty).

You don't deal with individual buyers, payment processing, or file delivery. The platform handles all of that. Your job is to create the book and make it discoverable.

Different platforms offer different royalty rates:

- **35% royalty:** Often the standard rate for books priced below a certain threshold (e.g., below $2.99 on Amazon KDP).

- **70% royalty:** Often available for books priced above a certain threshold (e.g., $2.99-$9.99 on Amazon KDP), with some conditions.

- **Direct selling (Gumroad, etc.):** You keep 85-95% of the sale price, minus processing fees.

The royalty structure affects your pricing strategy. We'll cover this in detail in the pricing chapter.

If you price your eBook at $4.99 on a platform with a 70% royalty:

- You earn ~$3.49 per sale.

- The platform keeps ~$1.50.

If you sell 10 copies per month: ~$34.90/month.

If you sell 100 copies per month: ~$349/month.

If you sell 1,000 copies per month: ~$3,490/month.

These are illustrative numbers. Actual sales depend on topic, quality, marketing, competition, and platform algorithms.

You write one eBook, publish it, and sell it. This is the starting point. One book, one topic, one platform. The goal of this book is to get you here.

After your first eBook, you write more. Each book cross-promotes the others. A reader who buys your first book and likes it buys your second. Your catalog compounds. This is how eBook businesses scale.

The Digital Income series you're reading right now is an example of Model 2 -- a catalog of related eBooks that cross-promote each other.

This book focuses on Model 1: getting your first eBook published and selling. Model 2 comes after.

eBooks can generate passive income -- money while you sleep -- but only after they're published, marketed, and have built momentum. The first months require active work: writing, publishing, marketing, getting reviews.

Some eBooks sell thousands of copies. Most sell dozens. The difference is usually topic selection, packaging, and marketing -- not writing quality. This book gives you the tools to be in the group that sells, not the group that doesn't.

Your eBook doesn't need to be a literary masterpiece. It needs to deliver value to the reader -- clear, actionable information that solves a problem or teaches a skill. Clarity beats eloquence in the eBook business.

Publishing platforms take a cut. Cover design costs money (or time). Marketing takes effort. You'll invest time and some money upfront, then earn royalties over time. The investment-to-return ratio can be excellent -- but it's not zero-cost.

Before moving to the next chapter, answer these questions:

- What topic or expertise could you write about?

- Who would want to read about this topic? (What type of person?)

- What problem would your eBook solve for them?

- Are you willing to treat this as a business -- not just a creative project?

Write these answers down. By the end of this book, you'll have a published eBook on a platform, earning royalties. But first, let's make sure you're writing something people actually want to buy.

Choosing a Topic With Market Demand